Case ETH-TIG-001 - The Tigray War (2020-2022) and the Post-Pretoria Period

Status: research-backed seed case + fictional simulation inputs

As of: 1 November 2026

Geographic scope: Ethiopia (Tigray, Amhara, Afar), Eritrea; African Union mediation

Purpose: case creation, evidence-aware graph extraction and multi-agent scenario exploration in M2 Swarm

Research integrity. Named officials, parties and governments appear only through reported public positions at cited dates. All persona comments in the synthetic section are written for simulation: they are not quotations, not scraped posts, not real people, not polling data and not predictions. Contested figures are given as ranges with their sources. Where sources disagree, both are recorded.

1. Case question

How did the war in Tigray unfold between November 2020 and November 2022, how did the federal government, the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF), Eritrea and international bodies present it, and how has the implementation of the Pretoria agreement developed since? Under hypothetical scenarios, how might government-aligned, government-critical and TPLF-aligned viewpoints (synthetic only) interact?

2. Analytical boundaries

- Record violations as attributed in the cited investigations: the EHRC-OHCHR report found violations by all parties.
- Give casualty figures only as sourced ranges; the true toll is contested and may never be known.
- Do not resolve contested characterisations (for example, genocide allegations made by Tigrayan groups and some scholars, which the federal government rejects); record who makes each claim.
- Do not generalise from any ethnic group to individuals; no dehumanising language in any persona or post.
- The full text of the Pretoria agreement was not officially published; provisions are cited from secondary summaries.
- Synthetic personas represent viewpoints for testing only. They are never evidence of what real people think.
- Do not create statements in the names of real officials, parties or governments; real actors are context-only.

3. Documented timeline

Each line is a sourced statement. Items marked *[verify]* are widely reported but were not re-checked against a primary source for this file; confirm before approving them in the graph.

- **4 November 2020.** Fighting erupted between federal forces and the TPLF in Tigray after an attack on the Northern Command of the Ethiopian National Defense Force; the federal government launched military operations. (S01 [verify])
- **28 November 2020.** Federal forces entered Mekelle, the Tigray regional capital. *[verify]*
- **23 March 2021.** Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed acknowledged the presence of Eritrean troops in Tigray after denying it for months. (S02)
- **3 April 2021.** The Ethiopian Ministry of Foreign Affairs said Eritrean forces had started withdrawing from Tigray; residents disputed this. (S03)
- **May 2021.** The Ethiopian parliament designated the TPLF a terrorist organisation. *[verify]*
- **June 2021.** Federal forces withdrew from Mekelle and the government declared a unilateral ceasefire; Tigrayan forces later advanced into Amhara and Afar. *[verify]*

- **Summer 2021.** According to the US State Department, Iran delivered Mohajer-6 armed drones to Ethiopia, which the Ethiopian military used in Tigray. (S04)
- **3 November 2021.** The Ethiopian Human Rights Commission (EHRC) and the UN Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR) published a joint investigation finding violations by the Ethiopian National Defense Force, the Eritrean Defense Forces, the Tigray Defense Forces, Amhara special forces and Fano militias. (S05)
- **6 November 2021.** Canada, New Zealand, Australia and other governments issued a joint statement calling the findings grave and urging all parties to implement the report's recommendations. (S06)
- **2 November 2022.** The Ethiopian federal government and the TPLF signed the Agreement for Lasting Peace through a Permanent Cessation of Hostilities in Pretoria under African Union mediation. (S07, S08)
- **15 January 2023.** African Union mediator Olusegun Obasanjo said up to 600,000 people may have died in the war; Ethiopian officials cited lower figures of 80,000 to 100,000, and researchers published ranges between these. (S09, S10)
- **March 2023.** Getachew Reda became president of the Tigray Interim Regional Administration. (S11)
- **13 February 2025.** The National Election Board of Ethiopia (NEBE) suspended the TPLF from political activity for three months for failing to hold a general assembly. (S12)
- **March-April 2025.** Getachew Reda was removed amid a split within the TPLF; Prime Minister Abiy appointed Tadesse Werede to lead the Tigray Interim Administration. (S11, S13)
- **May 2025.** NEBE deregistered the TPLF as a political party; the TPLF rejected the decision, arguing that the Pretoria agreement restored its legal status. (S14)
- **September 2025.** Interim president Tadesse Werede called the revocation of the TPLF's legal status unacceptable and urged a political settlement; the TPLF accused the guarantors of the Pretoria agreement of inaction. (S13, S15)
- **October 2025.** Prime Minister Abiy accused the TPLF of breaching the peace agreement and said the group could restore its legality by re-registering with NEBE. (S16)
- **February 2026.** Reporting described growing fears of armed confrontation between Ethiopia and Eritrea over Tigray and the border. (S17)

4. Actor perspectives (documented)

Federal Government of Ethiopia / Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed

Presented the 2020 operations as a response to the attack on the Northern Command; signed the Pretoria agreement in 2022; in 2025 said the TPLF may regain legal status by re-registering. Sources S02, S07, S16.

Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF)

Party to the Pretoria agreement; disputes its deregistration and argues Pretoria restored its pre-war status; accuses guarantors of inaction. Internally split since 2025. Sources S14, S15.

Tigray Interim Regional Administration

Led by Getachew Reda (2023-2025) and then Tadesse Werede; Tadesse called for a political settlement of the TPLF's status. Sources S11, S13.

Eritrea / Eritrean Defense Forces

Took part in the war alongside federal forces (acknowledged March 2021); not a signatory to Pretoria; relations with Addis Ababa deteriorated afterwards. Sources S02, S05, S17.

African Union mediation panel

Mediated Pretoria; mediator Olusegun Obasanjo gave the highest public death-toll estimate. Sources S07, S09.

EHRC and OHCHR

Joint investigation covering 3 November 2020 to 28 June 2021; criticised by some Tigrayan and advocacy groups because the EHRC is a state body. Source S05.

5. Entity categories and relationships

Entity categories: Person, Organization (parties, armed forces, commissions, media), Country, Location (Tigray, Mekelle, Western Tigray, Amhara, Afar), Event, Policy (Pretoria agreement, terrorist designation, NEBE decisions), Topic (humanitarian access, displacement, accountability, disarmament).

Relationship examples: PERSON -ANNOUNCED-> POLICY; ORGANIZATION -PARTICIPATED_IN-> EVENT; ORGANIZATION -OPPOSES-> POLICY; ORGANIZATION -REPORTS_ON-> EVENT. Every factual edge needs a cited passage. Do not infer coordination or alliance from two names appearing in the same sentence.

6. Synthetic persona archetypes (fictional - for simulation only)

All personas below are fictional archetypes written for M2 Swarm testing. They are not real people and their lines are not real posts. Import them into an environment as synthetic agents; keep real actors context-only. Stance axis for this case: -1.0 = strongly critical of the federal government's handling of the war and peace process, +1.0 = strongly supportive.

Topic codes: T01 peace and security; T02 political settlement and legal status; T03 humanitarian recovery and displacement; T04 accountability and information integrity.

- **SIM01 - Addis Ababa civil servant (Ethiopia; government-aligned)** [stance +0.7]: “The Pretoria agreement ended the fighting. The priority now is disarmament and rebuilding under the constitution.” [simulation topic T01]
- **SIM02 - Small-business owner in Bahir Dar (Ethiopia; government-aligned)** [stance +0.5]: “My customers want roads open and prices stable. Peace has to be protected before anything else.” [simulation topic T03]
- **SIM03 - Retired teacher in Adama (Ethiopia; cautiously supportive)** [stance +0.3]: “I support the peace deal, but people need to see accountability, not only speeches.” [simulation topic T04]
- **SIM04 - Diaspora engineer in Washington DC (Ethiopian diaspora; government-aligned)** [stance +0.6]: “Investment will follow stability. Every side should commit to the agreement in practice.” [simulation topic T01]
- **SIM05 - University lecturer in Addis Ababa (Ethiopia; government-critical)** [stance -0.5]: “Ending one war did not end the political crisis. Conflicts elsewhere in the country show that.” [simulation topic T02]
- **SIM06 - Opposition party volunteer (Ethiopia; government-critical)** [stance -0.6]: “Peace needs an inclusive political dialogue, not decisions made by a few people at the top.” [simulation topic T02]
- **SIM07 - Freelance journalist (Ethiopia; verification-focused)** [stance -0.2]: “Every casualty figure in this war is disputed. I want independent access before anyone claims certainty.” [simulation topic T04]
- **SIM08 - Health worker in Mekelle (Tigray, Ethiopia; TPLF-aligned)** [stance -0.7]: “Clinics are still short of medicine. Until services fully return, people here will not feel the war is over.” [simulation topic T03]
- **SIM09 - Displaced farmer from Western Tigray (Tigray, Ethiopia; TPLF-aligned)** [stance -0.8]: “The agreement promised that displaced people could go home. Many of us are still waiting in camps.” [simulation topic T03]
- **SIM10 - Tigrayan student in Addis Ababa (Ethiopia; TPLF-sympathetic)** [stance -0.5]: “I want peace and a future here. The dispute over the TPLF's legal status should be solved by talks.” [simulation topic T02]
- **SIM11 - Tigrayan diaspora activist (Ethiopian diaspora; TPLF-aligned)** [stance -0.8]: “Accountability for abuses documented by investigators must be part of any lasting peace.” [simulation topic T04]
- **SIM12 - Afar pastoralist leader (Afar, Ethiopia; neutral)** [stance +0.0]: “Our communities were also hit by the war. Recovery funds should reach every affected region.” [simulation topic T03]
- **SIM13 - Humanitarian logistics officer (Regional; neutral)** [stance +0.0]: “Access for aid convoys is the measure that matters to families, whatever the politics.” [simulation topic T03]
- **SIM14 - Horn of Africa analyst (Regional; analytical)** [stance +0.0]: “The key risk now is the triangle between Addis Ababa, Mekelle and Asmara, not the 2020 front lines.” [simulation topic T01]
- **SIM15 - Peace-building NGO worker (Ethiopia; peace-focused)** [stance +0.1]: “Disarmament, return of the displaced and transitional justice must move together or none will hold.” [simulation topic T01]

7. Test scenarios (hypothetical)

- **Scenario 1 - Pretoria implementation advances.** Disarmament and return of displaced people progress on schedule; explore how each viewpoint reacts to visible delivery versus announcements.
- **Scenario 2 - Political deadlock over legal status.** Talks on the TPLF's registration stall; compare how government-aligned, government-critical and TPLF-aligned personas frame the impasse.

- **Scenario 3 - Border escalation risk.** Reports of troop movements near the Eritrean border circulate; test how calls for restraint and verification spread compared with alarm.
- **Scenario 4 - Information disorder.** An unverified casualty claim spreads; test source checking and correction behaviour without attributing invented quotes to real actors.

8. Suggested M2 Swarm settings

Field	Value
Case title	The Tigray War (2020-2022) and the Post-Pretoria Period (ETH-TIG-001)
Research question	Section 1 of this document.
Primary scope	Country
Tags	ethiopia, tigray, tplf, pretoria agreement, eritrea, african union, humanitarian
Entity types	All seven
Environment	Focus issue: Pretoria agreement; real actors context-only; import section 6 personas
Simulation	24 rounds; 1-2 LLM-written posts per round on a CPU-only machine

9. Sources

S01. Al Jazeera, 23 May 2023 - Protesters in Tigray demand Eritrean troops withdraw (background on November 2020). https://www.aljazeera.com/amp/news/2023/5/23/protesters-in-ethiopias-tigray-demand-eritrean-troops-withdraw

S02. Christian Science Monitor / Reuters, 26 March 2021 - Eritrea withdrawing troops from Tigray, Abiy says. https://csmonitor.com/World/Africa/2021/0326/Eritrea-withdrawing-troops-from-Tigray-Ethiopia-s-Abiy-says

S03. Al Jazeera, 4 April 2021 - Ethiopia says Eritrean troops started withdrawing from Tigray. https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2021/4/4/ethiopia-says-eritrean-troops-started-withdrawing-from-tigray

S04. Nation (Kenya) - US: Iran gave Ethiopia armed drones in Tigray war. https://nation.africa/africa/news/us-iran-gave-ethiopia-armed-drones-in-tigray-war-3991858

S05. EHRC - EHRC-OHCHR joint investigation report on the Tigray conflict, 3 November 2021. https://ehrc.org/download/ehrc-ohchr-joint-investigation-report-on-tigray-conflict/

S06. Global Affairs Canada - Joint statement on release of OHCHR-EHRC joint investigation, 6 November 2021. https://www.canada.ca/en/global-affairs/news/2021/11/joint-statement-on-release-of-ohchr-ehrc-joint-investigation-november-6-2021.html

S07. The EastAfrican, 2 November 2022 - Ethiopia, Tigray sign deal in Pretoria for cessation of hostilities. https://www.theeastafrican.co.ke/tea/rest-of-africa/ethiopia-tigray-sign-deal-to-cease-hostilities-4006688

S08. Daily Maverick, 2 November 2022 - Warring Ethiopian parties sign peace agreement in Pretoria. https://www.dailymaverick.co.za/article/2022-11-02-warring-ethiopian-parties-silence-the-guns-by-signing-historic-peace-agreement-in-pretoria.md

S09. Eye Radio, January 2023 - War in Tigray killed 600,000, AU mediator says. https://www.eyeradio.org/war-in-tigray-killed-600000-au-mediator/

S10. Wikipedia - Casualties of the Tigray war (overview of competing estimates; use only to locate primary studies). https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Casualties_of_the_Tigray_war

S11. Lawfare - Ethiopia's troubled peace (Tigray Interim Administration leadership changes). https://www.lawfaremedia.org/article/ethiopia-s-troubled-peace

S12. The Reporter Ethiopia - Election Board proscribes TPLF ahead of party's 50th anniversary. https://www.thereporterethiopia.com/43834/

S13. AllAfrica, September 2025 - Tigray interim president calls revocation of TPLF's legal status unacceptable. https://allafrica.com/stories/202509150068.html

S14. Eastleigh Voice, May 2025 - Ethiopia's electoral board deregisters the TPLF. https://eastleighvoice.co.ke/ethiopia%20tigray%20war/150281/ethiopia-s-electoral-board-deregisters-tigray-people-s-liberation-front-casting-uncertainty-over-peace-process

S15. AllAfrica, September 2025 - TPLF accuses guarantors of Pretoria agreement of inaction. https://allafrica.com/stories/202509300370.html

S16. AllAfrica, October 2025 - PM Abiy accuses TPLF of breaching peace deal. https://allafrica.com/stories/202510290001.html

S17. Africanews, 9 February 2026 - Ethiopia-Eritrea tensions: fears of armed confrontation grow. https://www.africanews.com/2026/02/09/ethiopia-eritrea-tensions-fears-of-armed-confontation-grow/

Completion criteria: every historical statement in the approved graph links to a source passage; no synthetic persona is presented as a real person; real officials and institutions are context-only in simulations; simulated results are never reported as public opinion or forecasts.